



Do some research about pain relief to become as informed as you can and weigh the pros and cons of each option. Speak to your doctor if anything is unclear.

ASK A PANEL

What if I can't deal with the pain of labor?

Doctor: If you're concerned, take time to investigate the pain-relief options in advance of labor, so that you're aware of what's available, even if you don't plan to use it.

There's no shame in deviating from what you requested in your birth plan; the ultimate goal is to deliver a healthy baby, and to keep your energy levels and your spirits high. It's also important to ask for pain relief as soon as you feel that things are getting away from you.

Mom: When I was in labor, the pain literally took my breath away, and I really did feel that I would be unable to continue. Changing position, walking around, and using a birthing ball proved to be a good distraction, even if they passed the time rather than provided relief, and I chanted to myself, over and over, "You can do it!"

I dimly remembered that when the pain is at its worst you've hit "transition," which signals the beginning of the delivery itself, and it did help to know I was near the end, even if it did seem a